This week had 2 lessons. The first was how to pitch. A good pitch has four parts: problem, solution, impact, and ask. The part that stuck with me is to start with a real person, not the product. “Many beginners are confused” is weak. “Meet my coworker, who just wants someone to explain what the numbers mean” makes people care. I also learned to show one full user journey instead of listing every feature.

The second lesson was scope. Everything takes about three times longer than you think. Every successful student last year cut features, and the ones who cut early had calmer build weeks.

This hit home for my investing app. I have already built a lot: a market dashboard, a watchlist, the Vantage Score, charts, news, hover definitions, and the Ask Vantage assistant. When I asked myself, “What is the smallest version that still proves the idea?” the answer was simple. One stock page that explains its numbers in plain English. Everything else is extra. For my pitch, I will walk through one journey: a beginner opens a stock, sees a confusing term, and asks Ask Vantage what it means.

The hardest part is letting go of features I like. As a developer, it feels wrong to cut something that already works. But more features also mean more things to debug. I need to keep my must-have list to five items or fewer. I also need to stop reading with how the app works and start with the problem.